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Boston's Floating Hospital and the nurses whose work redefined infant care

Boston, MA—In the US, nurses have a long history of being overworked, underpaid, and underappreciated. Making progress on these conditions often requires a fight on the part of nurses: the past ten years have seen multiple historic nursing strikes at hospitals such as the Tufts Medical Center in Boston, Vincent Hospital in Worcester, MA, and New York-Presbyterian Hospital, to name a few.

In *Harbor of Hope: Nurses of the Boston Floating Hospital* (October 2026, University of Massachusetts Press), Arlene W. Keeling shines a light on the late nineteenth-century nurses who transformed pediatric care aboard Boston's Floating Hospital. The book highlights the overlooked role of nurses and explores how “nursing and medicine were two sides of the same coin, both essential to the functioning of the Floating Hospital and the decrease in infant mortality that resulted,” as stated by Keeling in the introduction.

“Most histories of the Boston Floating Hospital focus on the physicians’ contributions,” says Keeling. *Harbor of Hope* works to bring nurses to the forefront of the narrative to remind readers of the prominent role nurses play in public healthcare.

“In vivid prose, Keeling weaves a compelling narrative that brings the reader onto the boat, whisking them alongside the nurses as they swiftly move around the decks, tending their charges,” says Meghan L. Crnic, author of *The Beach Cure: A History of Healing on Northeastern Shores*. “It’s an exciting trip back in time and an important contribution to the history of nursing.”

Through an in-depth analysis of hospital records and primary sources to document the detailed care that nurses provided on board, the novel also situates their work within the larger context of Boston itself at the turn of the twentieth century, highlighting the role of religious charities, the goals of the Progressive Era, and the summer crusades to save babies.

“*Harbor of Hope* adds depth and breadth to our understanding of the work nurses did in establishing the Boston Floating Hospital, and to the wider contributions they have made and will continue to make in health care,” says Sandra Leweson, author of *Taking Charge: Nursing, Suffrage, and Feminism in America, 1873-1920*. “Keeling is an outstanding writer, and I found it hard to put the book down.”

To request a review copy or an interview with the author, please contact Chelsey Harris, University of Massachusetts Press Marketing and Sales Director, at umpmarketing@umpress.umass.edu.

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